# Lesson 15: Indigenous People: Discussion, Listening and Reading

*English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 2: Sentences and Paragraph Types · American History*

*Adapted from High-Intermediate Academic Grammar for ESL Students by Rebecca Al Haider, Reedley College (CC BY 4.0): 5.1: Discussion; 5.2: Listening-Lakota in America; 5.3: Reading-Life on Reservations; 16.4: Chapter 4 (audio transcript).*

## In this lesson

You will watch a short documentary, "Lakota in America", about a Lakota teenager and a youth project on the Cheyenne River reservation, and read an article, "Life on Reservations", about the history of Native American reservations and the challenges people face there today. You will practice the two-part questions used in academic reading tests: first choose the central idea, then choose the evidence that supports it. The reading is also the base for this chapter's grammar lessons on modals (Lesson 16) and adjective clauses (Lesson 19).

## Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain what a reservation is and why the U.S. government created reservations.
- Describe the main challenges on reservations and the ways tribes keep their cultures alive.
- Choose the central idea of a text and the quotation that best supports it (Part A and Part B questions).
- Use new words such as indigenous, tribe, heritage, assimilation and life expectancy.
- Write a short discussion post about the history of a group, with examples.

## Key language

| Word or phrase | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| indigenous (adj) | belonging to the first people who lived in a place | Who is indigenous to those lands? |
| reservation (n) | a large area of land kept for a Native American tribe and governed by the tribe | Reservations have existed since 1830. |
| tribe (n) | a group of families with the same ancestors, language, culture and leaders | Each tribe had its own government, culture, traditions … |
| settler (n) | a person who moves to a new area to live on the land | As more settlers traveled West … |
| relocate (v) | to move people to a new place; "by force" means against their will | They were often relocated by force. |

| Word or phrase | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| heritage (n) | the history, culture and traditions that a group passes to the next generation | Many younger generations became disconnected from their heritage. |
| preservation (n) | keeping something so that it is not lost | the preservation of tribal languages |
| immersion (n) | learning a language by using only that language, every day | daily language immersion with elders |
| pow-wow (n) | a community event with singing, dancing and ceremonies that celebrate Native American culture | Today, pow-wows happen all over the country. |
| economically disadvantaged (adj) | poor; with less money and fewer chances than other people | Not all reservations are as economically disadvantaged as Pine Ridge. |
| life expectancy (n) | the average number of years that people live | The life expectancy on the Pine Ridge Indian Reservation is 48 years for men. |
| assimilation (n) | making a group give up its own culture and become like the majority | "Moving us to reservations and the assimilation of our people." |
| descendant (n) | a person in a later generation of a family | I'm the descendant of Chief Iron Lightning. |
| internship (n) | a period of work for a young person to learn job skills | Our internships at CRYP provide a way out for our young people. |

## Rules and explanations

### The video: "Lakota in America"

- A short documentary (about 14 minutes). The main speakers are **Genevieve Iron Lightning**, a Lakota teenager whose Lakota name means "Stands First Woman", and **Julie**, from the Cheyenne River Youth Project (CRYP). Wakiya also speaks about Lakota history.
- Place: Eagle Butte, on the Cheyenne River reservation, "one of the poorest counties in the nation".
- The CRYP offers internships (for example at the Keya Cafe), wellness programs, the arts, a teen center, a gymnasium, a dance studio, a computer lab and a garden.

### The reading: "Life on Reservations"

The article by Jessica McBirney (CommonLit) has 16 numbered paragraphs: an introduction (1) and five sections: Why Reservations? (2-4), Reservation Life Today (5-9), Economic Challenges (10-12), Physical and Mental Health (13-14), Stress and School (15-16).

| Topic | Key facts from the reading |
|---|---|
| People | About 5.2 million Native Americans live in the U.S.; 22% of them live on reservations. |
| History | Reservations have existed since 1830. The "Trail of Tears" was a series of forced relocations to areas west of the Mississippi; over 4,000 Native Americans died. |

| Topic | Key facts from the reading |
|---|---|
| Culture | language immersion programs with elders; stomp dances and stickball; pow-wows |
| Economy | Pine Ridge (South Dakota): average income under $4,000 per family per year; eight in ten adults have no job |
| Housing | a wait list for a house can be up to three years; over 50% of houses are not connected to public sewers |
| Health | government-funded health care meets about 60% of needs; at Pine Ridge, life expectancy is 48 (men) and 52 (women) |

### Part A and Part B questions

- **Part A** asks a big question: the **central idea** (the main point of the whole text) or what one section adds to the text ("How does the section … contribute to the development of ideas?").
- The central idea must be true for the **whole** text. Wrong options are often too narrow (one detail only), the opposite of the text, or not in the text at all.
- **Part B** asks for **evidence**: the quotation that best supports your Part A answer. Answer Part A first. Several quotations may be true; choose the one that proves your Part A answer most directly.

### History and today: verb tenses

- The text uses the **simple past** for history: "The U.S. government created reservations …"
- It uses the **simple present** for facts about today: "Many tribes continue to practice key parts of their distinct cultures."
- Do the same when you write or speak about history.

## Practice

**Discussion (before you watch).** Answer the three questions aloud to your tutor, or record yourself with your phone. Then write a post (see "Writing task"). Minoritized groups are groups that a society treats as minorities, with less power.

1. Think about the countries around the world. Who is indigenous to those lands? Who occupied those lands? Provide examples.
2. Think about the groups of people in the United States. How did the US become so diverse?
3. Are you familiar with the history of how minoritized groups in the US (e.g., Indigenous people, African Americans, Asian Americans, Muslims, Sikhs, immigrants, refugees, etc.) have been treated? Explain.

**Exercise 1: Listening comprehension.** Watch "Lakota in America" first, without the transcript: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ie4m9LAVDGw. Answer the questions. Then watch again while you read the transcript at the end of the lesson material, and check your answers. In questions 1 and 2, select all the correct answers.

1. Select all the ways the Cheyenne River Youth Project helps youth. a) Mental Health b) Physical Health c) Education d) Financial Literacy

2. Select the challenges Lakota people reservation face. a) Poverty b) Alcoholism and substance abuse c) Suicide d) Unemployment e) Housing
3. Why was the Lakota culture being lost?
    - a) It was illegal to practice the Lakota culture and religion.
    - b) The youth weren't interested in learning.
    - c) The elders weren't interested in passing down the traditions.
4. What is seen as wealth for Lakota people? a) Money b) Culture and tradition c) Houses and cars
5. How many internships were completed in 2017? a) 50 b) 100 c) 250 d) 500

**Exercise 2: Reading comprehension.** Read "Life on Reservations" in the lesson material. Then answer.

1. PART A: Which of the following identifies the central idea of the text?
    - a) Life on reservations has vastly improved due to the involvement of the United States government.
    - b) Native Americans continue to face significant challenges on reservations that negatively impact their quality of life.
    - c) Most Native Americans eventually leave reservations due to the lack of opportunity and unsafe environments.
    - d) While reservation schools have less funding, they are more successful due to their integration of Native American cultures in the classroom.
2. PART B: Which detail from the text best supports the answer to Part A?
    - a) "The U.S. government tried to install its own forms of education, work, and family life onto the reservations to weaken the Native Americans connection to their cultures and tribes." (Paragraph 4)
    - b) "Not all reservations are as economically disadvantaged as Pine Ridge, but many have unemployment rates in the double digits, and many households rely only on government benefits for income." (Paragraph 10)
    - c) "Many live without the many utilities most of America takes for granted. For example, over 50% of houses on reservations are not even connected to public sewers, and some have no running water." (Paragraph 12)
    - d) "Native American students who participate in the immersion programs mentioned at the beginning of this article often have higher academic performance and test scores later in life than students who did not receive dual language education." (Paragraph 16)
3. PART A: How does the section "Economic Challenges" contribute to the development of ideas in the text (Paragraphs 10-12)?
    - a) It shows how the economic issues that Native Americans face on reservations result in several other related problems.

- b) It emphasizes the need for additional jobs to be available on reservations so families are not separated.
- c) It proves that the reservations need additional funding from the U.S. government to fulfill their basic needs.
- d) It shows that not all reservations across the country are struggling, and that quality of life can vary dramatically.

4. PART B: Which quote from the text best supports the answer to Part A?
   - a) "Not all reservations are as economically disadvantaged as Pine Ridge, but many have unemployment rates in the double digits" (Paragraph 10)
   - b) "Meanwhile, they have to leave their children with other relatives or friends. All the economic hardship strains family relationships." (Paragraph 11)
   - c) "Most reservations have severe housing shortages - a wait list for a house could be up to three years long." (Paragraph 12)
   - d) "[O]ver 50% of houses on reservations are not even connected to public sewers, and some have no running water." (Paragraph 12)

## Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me the three discussion questions from Lesson 15, one at a time. After each answer, ask me one follow-up question. Correct my verb tenses."
- "I will retell Genevieve's story from 'Lakota in America' in six or seven sentences. Check my facts and my grammar."
- "Ask me why the U.S. government created reservations and what problems people on reservations face today. Help me use the words heritage, assimilation and life expectancy."
- "Quiz me on these numbers from 'Life on Reservations': 5.2 million, 22%, 1830, 4,000, $4,000, 48 and 52. I will explain what each number means."
- "Explain why the wrong options in Exercise 2, questions 1 and 3, are wrong."

## Read aloud

- Who is indigenous to those lands? (in·DIG·e·nous)
- Reservations have existed since 1830. (res·er·VA·tions; 1830 = eighteen thirty)
- Many younger generations became disconnected from their heritage. (HER·i·tage)
- Some tribes have programs that allow young students to experience daily language immersion with elders. (im·MER·sion)
- The life expectancy on the Pine Ridge Indian Reservation is 48 years for men and 52 for women. (ex·PEC·tan·cy)
- I'm the descendant of Chief Iron Lightning. (de·SCEN·dant)
- It's important for our young people to remember where they come from.

## Writing task

Write a discussion post of 150-200 words that answers two or three of the discussion questions.

- Start with one sentence that gives your main answer.
- Give at least two specific examples (a country, a group, an event).
- Use the simple past for history and the simple present for today.
- Use at least four words from the Key language table.

Checklist:

- Does every sentence have a subject and a verb?
- Are past events in the simple past (created, moved, lost)?
- Are facts about today in the simple present (live, face, continue)?
- Did you spell the names of groups with capital letters (Native Americans, Lakota, Indigenous people)?
- Are your facts correct? Check them against the reading.
- Did you use at least four new words correctly?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

## Watch online

- Lakota in America (the video for Exercise 1): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ie4m9LAVDGw
- North Dakota Access Pipeline (What Really Happened at Standing Rock: I Was There): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=J1yD2J8vHAk
- Missing and Murdered Indigenous Women (Indigenous Women Keep Going Missing in Montana): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ib0GDAPeymo
- Residential Schools (How the US Stole Thousands of Native American Children): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=UGqWRyBCHhw
- How do Indigenous people feel about reservations? Word associations (Reservation/Native Americans/One Word/Cut): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=OOWUDM1GBhk

## Answer key

**Discussion.** (example answer)

1. In the United States, Native American nations such as the Lakota and the Cherokee are indigenous to the land. European settlers occupied it and moved west, and the government put many tribes on reservations.
2. The US became diverse because people came from many parts of the world: immigrants and refugees came from Europe, Asia, Latin America and the Middle East, and many Africans were brought by force as slaves.
3. I know a little. Native Americans lost most of their land, and many were relocated by force; over 4,000 died on the Trail of Tears. Today many reservations are still poor.

**Exercise 1.** (book)

1. a, b, c, d. Julie: "We're talking about their mental health, their physical health, their education." The internships teach "how to manage money" (financial literacy).
2. a, b, c, d, e. The video mentions poverty, alcohol and meth, suicides, few job opportunities and poor houses.
3. a. Wakiya: "It was against the law." (05:49)
4. b. Julie: "I think we see family and culture and tradition and singing and dancing as … wealth." (12:24)
5. d. This number is not in the transcript.

**Exercise 2.** (book)

1. b. The whole text shows problems that continue today: poverty, housing, health and schools.
2. c. Houses without sewers or running water show how the challenges hurt quality of life.
3. a. The section moves from poverty to the problems it causes: parents leave to find work, and families crowd into houses.
4. b. "All the economic hardship strains family relationships" shows an economic problem causing another problem.

## My notes